MOUNTAIN OF THE MONTH

ALYESKA ALASKA

By Jeff Foss

QUICK STATS

Trails: 62 **Lifts:** 10
Summit Elevation: 3,939 ft.
Base Elevation: 250 ft.
Total Vertical: 2,500 ft.
Average Annual Snowfall:
Base: 189"
Midway: 489"
Peak: 583"

Snowmaking: Conditional
Skiable Terrain:
Beginner: 5%
Intermediate: 30%
Expert: 65%
Lift Ticket: Non-resident $45, Resident $39 ($27 with high school ID)
Season Pass: Adult $999, Student $825

Reservations: 800-880-3880
Snow Report: 907-754-7669
Web: www.alyeskaresort.com

In a world where skiing progresses almost exponentially from one year to the next, Alaska will always be up to the challenge. An obscene amount of snow is generated here every season, hanging impossibly from the sheer faces and dizzying chutes of countless towering peaks. Located on the south central coast of the Chugach Mountain Range, AK's finest ski area is Alyeska Resort. But don't let the name fool you…the mountain itself is about as far from the "resort" experience as you can get.

Alyeska 101

Legend has it some **crazy Alaskan local named Max** used to tear up the mountains surrounding Alyeska long before there were any ski lifts around. Truth be told, **Alyeska Resort** opened for business in **1959**, making it one of the oldest ski areas in Alaska and surprisingly, one of the few. Those **damn Northerners** are intent on keeping as much of that incredible skiing as possible to themselves.

Dumping Allowed

The **snowstorms** that hammer this part of the world during the long Winter season are **merciless**. During one particularly insane two-week span at Alyeska it snowed a ridiculous **110 inches**. That's over nine feet in 14 days! The only non-Alaskan who has ever experienced that much snow is **Colombian drug-lord Pablo Escobar**.

Park and Pipe

With so much great backcountry skiing around, Alaska itself is a **natural terrain park** during the winter. You'll find a **man-made park** at Alyeska, however, as well as **Alaska's largest and only machine-made halfpipe**. At just **250-feet long** with **10-foot walls**, Alyeska's pipe may be the only thing in Alaska that isn't bigger and badder than its continental counterparts.

North Stars

Many of the more well-known skiers you'll find at Alyeska are actually visitors from somewhere in the lower 48. **Jeremy Nobis** and **Seth Morrison** often cruise by "Aly" on their way to and from filming big mountain segments in Alaska's backcountry. **TGR henchmen Dirk Collins and Todd Jones** tear it up at Alyeska on a regular basis, as does Olympic racer **Tommy Moe**, now a part owner of **Chugach Powder Guides**. The Heli and Snowcat skiing this company offers isn't cheap—$650 and $150 for one full day, respectively—but afterwards it'll take an **industrial-strength floor buffer** to wipe the smile off your face.

Aurora Borealis

Make your stay at Alyeska memorable by pampering yourself silly at the **Royal Prince Hotel**. There isn't a whole lot else going on in the town of **Girdwood**, but there's plenty of fun to be had in **Anchorage**, just 30 minutes away. **Humpy's** is a great place to grab a drink and a bite to eat, but it's rather low-key compared to **Chilcutt Charlie's**—a massive complex with eight individually-themed bars. If you're keen to other forms of entertainment, the aptly-named **Alaskan Bush Company** is a world-renowned strip joint where one dollar will get you everything you bargained for… and then some.